AMERICAN VOICES

1.2 Thomas Jefferson 1743–1826

"I like the dreams of the future better than the history of the past." —Thomas Jefferson

A gifted writer, architect, scientist—you name it—Thomas Jefferson had the chops to carry out his dreams. He proposed a plan that laid the basis of our school system, restocked the Library of Congress with his own books, and penned America's creed. At a dinner at the White House in 1962, President John F. Kennedy remarked to a group of dignitaries that they represented the greatest talent ever assembled there, "with the possible exception of when Thomas Jefferson dined alone."

MONTICELLO

Because Jefferson was born into one of Virginia's foremost families, he received an education that allowed his natural abilities to flourish. As a young man, he studied law and, in time, developed a successful practice. While trying and winning most of the cases that came his way, the young lawyer met Martha Wayles Skelton, who would become his wife. A few years before they married, Jefferson began to design and build Monticello, which would be their home—aside from his years in the White House—for the rest of their lives.



New York Historical Society
New York City

American artist Rembrandt Peale painted this portrait in 1805 after Jefferson won reelection in a landslide victory. Jefferson posed for the portrait in the White House, wearing a cape with a fur-lined collar, perhaps to lend an air of informality to the painting.

Jefferson built Monticello on land in Charlottesville, Virginia, that he inherited from his father. The home became his architectural masterpiece, which he constantly reimagined and reworked over more than 40 years. The exterior of the house, with its columns and dome, was inspired by ancient Greek and Roman temples. The interior, with its 40-plus

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AMERICAN PLACES

Monticello, Charlottesville, Virginia

When Jefferson rebuilt the front of Monticello, he had the eight-sided dome, shown here, constructed. A radical design feature at the time, the dome was the first in America to be installed on top of a private residence.



rooms, held some of Jefferson's own inventions, including a "turning-machine" for holding and rotating the clothes in his closet.

The extensive gardens at Monticello also contained his inventions and improvements, such as a sundial and a plow that could easily lift and turn the soil cut by the machine. Jefferson was a dedicated gardener. He cultivated seeds he'd obtained from Europe and Mexico and even some from Lewis and Clark's westward expedition. Jefferson's gardens were a botanic laboratory where he used the scientific method to determine which seeds and plants grew best in its soil and climate.

MAN OF CONTRADICTIONS

Unfortunately, Jefferson's building projects at Monticello and his lavish lifestyle—he loved to entertain—caused him to fall deeply in debt. This may seem odd for a man who once said, "Never spend your money before you have it," but then, Jefferson was full of contradictions. In the Declaration of Independence, he wrote that "all men are created equal," yet he owned more than 100 slaves. And while George Washington granted freedom to many of his slaves in his will, Jefferson only freed a handful of his. He staunchly supported states' rights, but as president, greatly expanded the power of the national government. In many ways, he embodied the social and political contradictions of America itself.

Jefferson died at Monticello on July 4, 1826—50 years to the day after the signing of the Declaration of Independence. By a strange coincidence, his old friend and rival, John Adams, died on the same day. The pair had often locked horns politically but had always maintained a strong mutual respect. When Adams died, his last words were, "Thomas Jefferson survives." He didn't know that his friend had passed away just a few hours before.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were some of Jefferson's talents and accomplishments?
2. **EVALUATE** Why do you think it might have been difficult for Jefferson to live up to his principles?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think Adams might have been thinking of Jefferson in his last moments?

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